

ZIM ZALLAH BIM

The Truth Version

Chapter One — The Ambulance

My house doesn't have a hallway, a bathroom, a bedroom. It has Neverland, the Land of Oz, Wonderland, Narnia — I built every room around a world I loved, wall to wall, years before any of this happened. In the middle of Neverland sat the reason for all of it: a motor of my own design, the Serene Mota, three years and most of what I had built into a sphere of magnets that was never supposed to do what it did that afternoon.

I had the phone in my hand, filming. The sphere hit resonance, and the magnets went off all at once.

Whiz bang.

Four spots opened in my leg, so fast I didn't understand what they were until I looked down. One of them had found the femoral artery.

I ran — Neverland, past the Magic Mirror, through Wonderland, through Middle Earth, into the Land of Oz, the bathroom — leaving a trail the whole way. I called 911 and didn't wait for the operator to pick up. Set the phone down on the sink and turned around.

Back through the house the other direction — Land of Oz, Middle Earth, Wonderland, Neverland, past Walt's chair, into Narnia, the closet. I grabbed two belts. One around each leg, pulled as hard as I could get them.

I walked back to the bathroom with the tourniquets already on and picked the phone back up. The operator was still there. I gave my address — 8830 Longbow Place — and went to lie down in Wonderland while I waited, and that's when I looked up and saw it, the word I'd put above my own bed months before any of this: HEAVEN.

Then a knock. An ambulance was already in the driveway — not because my call had gotten there yet, it hadn't, but because it had been driving through the neighborhood empty, headed nowhere in particular, and it stopped at my door before my own 911 call had finished going through the system.

Five EMTs came in through a door that hadn't called for them.

I didn't have a name yet for what that meant. Lying there with two belts cutting off the blood to my own legs, I already knew I was going to spend a long time trying to answer one question: why that ambulance, on that street, in those exact thirty seconds.